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What Is a Hurricane?

The Saffir-Simpson Hurricane Scale

Category 5 – 137+ knots (157+ mph; 252+ km/h). Complete roof failure on most buildings. Many buildings destroyed, or structurally damaged beyond repair. Catastrophic storm surge damage. In the Northwest Pacific, a typhoon that reaches 150 mph (241 km/hr) is called a Super Typhoon.

SAFFIR-SIMPSON SCALE				
Category	Knots	MPH	KM/H	Damage
1	64-82	74-95	119-153	Minimal
2	83-95	96-110	154-177	Moderate
3	96-112	111-129	178-208	Extensive
4	113-136	130-156	209-251	Extreme
Super Typhoon	130+	150+	241+	Catastrophic
5	137+	157+	252+	Catastrophic

Tropical Cyclone Formation

These tropical waves, ideally embedded in the deep-layer easterly flow, contain a northeast wind shift. This is typically referred to as a “convergence”, where lines of equal atmospheric pressure are pressed together between the high-pressure ridge to the north and the developing low-pressure system. The divergence that results ahead of the convergence zone gives us a northeasterly wind as the axis of the tropical wave approaches. Gusts up to 25 mph may occur. Sometimes there can be gusts to tropical storm force in stronger waves. There can be next to no weather associated with these waves, and they may pass virtually unnoticed. More typically, there are bands of disturbed weather riding the axis of the wave. [Read more ...](#)